SOP: Land Your First AI Automation Client (Beginner Playbook)

What this is: A do-this-now operating procedure for going from zero clients to recurring revenue. Theory is stripped out. Every section is an action you take, a number you hit, or a script you send. Follow it in order.

The one goal that runs everything: Get **one real result for one real business**, documented. Not ten clients. Not a pipeline. One completed project with a measurable outcome you can point to. Everything in this SOP is built to get you that first case study as fast as possible, then stack revenue on top of it.

The 90-day target: - **Week 1 to 2:** Start outreach. Land first project (free or $500 to $1K). Begin delivering. - **Week 3 to 6:** Complete it. Document results into a case study. Use it to land paid projects ($1K to $3K). - **Week 6 to 12:** Convert a strong relationship into a retainer ($2,500 to $5K/month).

End state: 3 to 5 retainer clients = $9K to $25K/month. You do not need more than that.

PHASE 0 — Setup (Do today, about 60 minutes)

Do not "prepare" past this list. The moment these are done, you start sending messages.

- ☐ **Pick your service in one sentence.** "I build AI automations that [save time / cut cost / capture leads] for [type of business]." You can refine later. Write it down now.
- ☐ **Build your warm contact list (target: 40+ names).** Open your phone contacts, email, LinkedIn connections, old Slack/Discord, past coworkers, classmates, family, anyone who runs or works at a business. Dump every name into a spreadsheet. Do not filter yet. Quantity first.
- ☐ **Make the tracking sheet.** Columns: Name | Relationship | Company | Their likely problem | Channel (warm/Upwork) | Status | Last touch | Next action. This is your pipeline. You live in it daily.
- ☐ **Create your Upwork profile** (you'll work it in Phase 3, but set it up now so it's ready): clear title, your one-sentence service, list the tools/workflows you know. Leave it. Don't

polish for hours.

- ☐ **Install Loom** (free). You'll use it constantly.

Done? Stop preparing. Start Phase 1 the same day.

PHASE 1 — Warm Outreach (Week 1 to 2): Your Fastest Path to the First Case Study

Warm first because trust already exists. You skip the entire "prove you're legitimate" phase. Expect: **about 10 to 15 messages to 1 first project.** Far better odds than cold.

Step 1.1 — Prioritize your list

From your 40+ names, tag the **top 10** who either (a) run a business, (b) work somewhere with an obvious manual/repetitive process, or (c) are well-connected and would refer you. Start with these 10.

Step 1.2 — Send the warm message (target: 10 sent in 48 hours)

Keep it honest and low-pressure. You are not pitching a polished agency. You are someone learning AI automation looking for a first project. That truth converts.

Template A, contact who runs a business:

Hey [Name], I've been getting deep into AI automation, building systems that handle [repetitive task, e.g. lead follow-up / appointment booking / data entry] so businesses stop doing it manually. I'm taking on a first project or two at no/low cost to build out my results. Curious, is there a repetitive process in [their company] that eats time you wish would just run itself? Happy to show you a quick idea either way.

Template B, contact who could refer you:

Hey [Name], quick one. I've started building AI automations for businesses (think auto-booking, lead qualification, support workflows). I'm looking for one or two first projects to build my portfolio. Do you know anyone running a business who's drowning in a repetitive task? Even a maybe is helpful.

Rules: - One message, one clear thing you do, one easy question. No essays. - Don't lead with tools or tech. Lead with the problem you remove. - If you know their specific pain ("you

mentioned sorting leads eats your week"), name it.

Step 1.3 — Work the replies

- **They're interested:** book a 15-min call or offer to send a quick Loom (see Phase 2). Move fast; reply same day.
- **"Tell me more":** send Template + offer the demo.
- **No reply in 4 to 5 days:** one follow-up. *"No worries if the timing's off, just let me know if it's ever useful."* Then drop it.
- **"I don't have anything but [Person] might":** get the intro. That referral is now a warm contact.

Step 1.4 — Daily warm-outreach rhythm (until first project landed)

- ☐ Send/reach out to **5 new warm contacts per day**
- ☐ Follow up with everyone past the 4-day mark
- ☐ Log every touch in the sheet
- ☐ Book any call offered, same week

Exit criteria for Phase 1: One business says yes to a project (free or $500 to $1K). Move to delivery (Phase 4) immediately, but keep warm outreach running in the background.

PHASE 2 — The Loom Demo (Your Risk-Killer, use throughout)

A 5-minute Loom proves competence before any money changes hands. Use it to convert a lukewarm warm contact, or to open a cold prospect cold. It directly attacks the "can this person actually deliver?" doubt.

When to send one

- A warm contact is interested but hesitant.
- You spot a business (warm or cold) with an obvious broken/manual process you know how to fix.

The 5-minute Loom script (record in one take)

1. **(0:00 to 0:45) Name their problem.** "I noticed [your booking is phone-only during business hours / leads come in but nobody sorts them for hours]. Here's why that's

costing you..."

2. **(0:45 to 3:00) Show the solution.** Walk through how you'd build it. Show a mockup, a similar build, or screen-share the actual tool. Make them *see* it working.
3. **(3:00 to 4:00) State the outcome.** "The result: customers book 24/7, you stop losing the roughly 30% who won't call." Use a concrete number whenever you can.
4. **(4:00 to 5:00) Easy ask.** "If this is useful, happy to build a small version so you can see it on your own setup. No cost to find out if it's a fit."

Send it with one line: *"Made you a quick 5-min walkthrough of an idea for [company], no pitch, just wanted to show you what's possible."*

PHASE 3 — Cold Outreach on Upwork (Week 1 onward, runs in parallel)

Cold does **not** replace warm. You run both from day one. Warm gets you the fast first win; cold builds the pipeline that doesn't run out. Expect cold conversion: **about 50 messages to 5 replies to 2 calls to 1 client.** Volume is the whole game.

Order matters: Cold gets *dramatically* easier once you have one case study from warm. Don't wait to start it, but know your proposals get sharper after your first delivered result. Until then, lean on the Loom and on understanding their specific problem.

"But I don't have any case studies yet." Build demos instead.

This stops most beginners cold, and the fix is simple: if you don't have a case study, **build a demo of exactly what you would do for a client if you had one.** You don't need a paying client to prove competence. You need something real to show.

- **Pick a target type of business** (dental practices, landscapers, marketing agencies, e-commerce stores). Pick one you understand.
- **Find a real, obvious problem** that type of business has (phone-only booking, slow lead follow-up, manual data entry, no after-hours support).
- **Build the working automation for it as if they were already your client.** A functioning booking bot. A lead-qualification workflow. A support automation. Make it real, not a slide.
- **Record a Loom walking through it** (use the Phase 2 script). "Here's a 24/7 booking system I built for businesses like yours. Here's how it works, here's what it does for you."

That demo does everything a case study does at this stage: it answers "can this person actually deliver?" with proof they can *see*. You can attach it to Upwork proposals, send it to warm contacts, and lead cold messages with it. Build two or three demos for the business types you're targeting and you're never sending an empty-handed pitch again. Then your first real project replaces the demo with a documented result, and your proof gets even stronger.

Step 3.1 — Daily Upwork rhythm

- ☐ Respond to **10 relevant job posts per day**
- ☐ Filter for jobs where you genuinely understand the problem (automation, AI workflows, lead handling, booking, data tasks)
- ☐ Log each in the sheet

Step 3.2 — The proposal formula

A proposal that says "I can do this" loses to one that says "here's what I did for someone in your situation." Until you have a case study, substitute a relevant demo (above) plus deep understanding of *their* specific problem.

Structure (keep it short): 1. **Lead with their problem, restated.** Prove you read the post and get it. (Skip "Dear Sir, I am an expert...") 2. **One specific idea for how you'd solve it.** Concrete, not generic. 3. **Proof slot.** After Phase 4: "I built this exact thing for [client], [result]." Before that: link a demo or a 90-second Loom showing your approach to *their* job. 4. **One simple next step.** "Want me to record a quick walkthrough of how I'd build this for you?"

Step 3.3 — After your first case study

Rewrite your Upwork profile and every proposal to lead with it. The jump from zero proof to one proof is the biggest credibility leap you'll ever make, bigger than one-to-ten. Exploit it.

PHASE 4 — Deliver the First Project (Turn it into a case study)

The money on project #1 doesn't matter. The documented result is the entire point. Treat delivery as case-study production.

Step 4.1 — Scope it small and tight

- **One** automation. One workflow. One problem. Not a full overhaul, not a 6-month plan.
- Write down exactly what's in scope and what's not, in a message to the client, before you start. Your first client *will* want more; draw the line now and save the rest for "phase two."

Step 4.2 — Capture the baseline (critical, do this BEFORE you build)

You cannot prove improvement without a "before." Get the starting numbers: - Current time spent on the task per week - Current cost, error rate, response time, no-show rate, missed-lead rate, whatever the automation will move

Write them down.

Step 4.3 — Build and deliver on time

- Hit the deadline. On-time delivery is itself proof you're not a time-risk.
- Handle the back-and-forth and revisions cleanly. This is where you learn to talk in *their* language (time saved, money earned) instead of tools.

Step 4.4 — Measure the result

After it's live, capture the "after" numbers. Examples of the sentence you're building toward: - "Reduced response time from 4 hours to 12 minutes." - "Cut the no-show rate by 35%, booked 20 more appointments in month one." - "Automated lead qualification, conversion up 18%."

Step 4.5 — Write the one-page case study

This is your single most valuable asset. One page: 1. **The business** (type, no need for a famous name) 2. **The problem** (with the baseline number) 3. **What you built** (plain language) 4. **The result** (before to after, with the number) 5. **A client quote** if you can get one. Ask: *"Mind if I grab a sentence on how it's working for you?"*

Step 4.6 — Get the referral

Your delivered client is now your best referral source. Ask directly: *"Glad it's working. Do you know one other business owner who's stuck doing something repetitive? Happy to help them too."*

PHASE 5 — Climb the Revenue Ladder

Once the case study exists, the game changes. Run this progression:

Stage	What you do	Price
1. First project	Get one documented result	Free to $1K
2. Case study	Turn that result into your one-pager	(the real payoff)
3. Paid projects	Send case study to similar businesses, close on proof	$1K to $3K
4. Retainers	Convert strong clients to monthly	$3K to $5K/mo

Step 5.1 — Sell paid projects with the case study

Send your one-pager to 5 businesses similar to your first client. The pitch shifts from "I think I can" to "here's what I did for someone like you." Each project is another case study. Each case study makes the next sale easier and your price higher.

Step 5.2 — Convert to retainers (the actual goal)

When a project client is happy, propose ongoing work:

"I can keep managing and expanding your automations each month, optimizing what's running and finding the next time-sink to kill. Want me to put together a monthly plan?"

The trigger line you're listening for from a happy client: *"What else can you automate for us?"* That's your retainer opening.

The math that ends the grind: 3 clients x $3K = $9K/mo. 5 x $5K = $25K/mo. That's $108K to $300K/yr from **3 to 5 relationships**, not 30 to 50 one-off projects. A few strong relationships beat high volume every time.

The Daily Scorecard (Pin this until you have your first 2 clients)

Run this every working day. Consistency beats intensity. The people who hit 90 days are the ones who show up weekly, not the ones who sprint for two weeks and vanish.

- ☐ **5** new warm contacts reached
- ☐ **10** Upwork proposals sent
- ☐ **All** stale threads (4+ days) followed up
- ☐ **Any** Loom demos owed, recorded
- ☐ Pipeline sheet updated
- ☐ Booked calls happening this week

Weekly review (15 min): - How many messages sent vs. target? - Replies to calls to projects: where's the drop-off? - Is project #1 moving toward a documented result?

Hard Rules (the things that actually make or break it)

1. **Send before you're ready.** "Getting ready" forever is how 90% quietly quit. You know enough to have one conversation today.
2. **First project's job is the case study, not the fee.** Free/cheap here is an investment with a calculated ROI, not charity.
3. **Run warm and cold at the same time.** Warm for speed, cold for scale. Never just one.
4. **No case study? Build a demo.** Never pitch empty-handed. A working demo of what you'd build proves competence just as well.
5. **Scope small.** One problem, one automation, clear line on what's not included.
6. **Capture baseline numbers before you build.** No before means no provable result means no case study.
7. **Lead with their problem, never your tools.** Clients buy time saved and money earned.
8. **One piece of proof beats a perfect pitch.** Get it fast, then exploit it everywhere.
9. **Show up weekly.** The grind is an investment with a 60 to 90 day payoff. Don't sprint and burn out.

Want much more in-depth instruction on this process? Go here: [AI Automation Society Plus]